The rebirth of Krakatau

In 1883, volcanic eruptions devastated the Indonesian island of Krakatau, wiping out flora and fauna on the island and nearby Sertung and Panjang. By 1886, mosses, algae, flowering plants, and ferns had returned to Krakatau, borne either on the wind or as seeds on the surf. The first young trees emerged in 1887; various insect species, and a single lizard, were discovered in 1889. Recent research shows that the level of immigration to Krakatau and its neighbors peaked during the period of forest formation, from 1908 to 1921, but extinctions were at their height when the dense tree canopy prevented sunlight from reaching the forest floor, between 1921–33. Although the immigration of land birds and reptiles has almost stopped, new species of land mollusk and many insect groups are still arriving from Sumatra and Java, both just under 28 miles (45 km) away.